

Alberto López Ortega

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RESEARCH PROFILE

I investigate how social and political identities influence citizens' support for (il)liberal policies, contributing to strategies for strengthening liberal democratic resilience

EDUCATION

- Ph.D. Political Science, University of Zurich, 2021
Thesis: *A vote for diversity? Understanding voters' preferences for politicians through experimental innovations – Magna Cum Laude*
Advisor: Assoc. Prof. Oliver Strijbis
- M.S. Political and Electoral Analysis, Carlos III University (UC3M), 2017
Thesis: *The personalization of politics in parliamentary democracies: a conjoint experiment in Spain – 9.8/10*
Advisor: Assoc. Prof. Gema Garcia-Albacete
- B.S. Political Science, Pablo de Olavide University, 2016
Political Behavior Specialization
Thesis: *E-Gobernanza local en las RRSS: implicaciones politicas de Facebook y diseño de una estrategia de calidad – 9.75/10*
Advisor: Prof. Joaquín Salido Monge
- B.S. Law, Pablo de Olavide University, 2016
Constitutional Law Specialization
One-year Erasmus at University of Luxembourg (2014-2015)

APPOINTMENTS

- 2025- Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam
Assistant Professor, Faculty of Social Sciences
- 2024–25 Harvard University
Ramon Areces Fellow and Visiting Scholar, Center for European Studies
- 2021–24 Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam
Postdoctoral Researcher, Faculty of Social Sciences
- 2023 GESIS Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences
Visiting Scholar, Department of Data and Research on Society
- 2017 Duke University
Research Assistant, "Women in Combat" Project (PI: Prof. Laia Balcells)

RESEARCH AREAS

Identity politics: Examining how social identities influence political attitudes, prejudice, and discrimination

Democratic backsliding: Analyzing the role of identity-based polarization in undermining liberal democratic norms

Experimental methods: Developing innovative approaches to studying discriminatory attitudes, including visual conjoint experiments and AI-powered methods

LGBTQ+ politics: Investigating conditional support for sexual minorities and strategic liberalism across cultural contexts

PUBLICATIONS

Journal Articles

- Forth. “Not So Sexually Modern After All: A Conjoint Experiment on Adoption Parent Candidates.” A. López Ortega and A. Blanco. *Public Opinion Quarterly*.
- 2025 “When the Party is Over: Explaining the Rise of the Spanish Far-Right SALF.” J.P. Moreno-Torres, Á. Canalejo-Molero, and A. López Ortega. *Research & Politics*.
- 2025 “Radical Right Normalization & Centrifugal Affect. Evidence from the Dating Market.” S. Turnbull-Dugarte and A. López Ortega. *Journal of Politics*
- 2025 “Do Citizens Stereotype Muslims as an Illiberal Bogeyman? Evidence from a Double-list Experiment.” S. Turnbull-Dugarte, A. López Ortega, and M. Hunklinger. *British Journal of Political Science*.
- 2025 “Trust in scientists and their role in society across 68 countries.” TISP team (including A. López Ortega). *Nature Human Behavior*.
- 2025 “How congruent are populist parties with their constituencies? Evidence from the 2019 European Parliament Elections in Italy, the Netherlands, Germany and Sweden.” A. Zhirnov, J.P. Thomeczek, M. Scotto Di Vettimo, A. López Ortega, A. Krouwel, L. Antonucci, R. Di Stefano, and N. Kersting. *Electoral Studies*.
- 2024 “Visual Conjoint vs. Text Conjoint and the Differential Discriminatory Effect of (Visible) Social Categories.” A. López Ortega and M. Radojevic. *Political Behavior*.
- 2024 “Bisexual erasure and homophobia: attitudinal patterns under consideration of sexual identity.” C. Wurthmann, A. López Ortega. *European Journal of Politics and Gender*.
- 2024 “The War on Flags: The Opposition to Symbolic Politics of Gender and Sexual Equality.” A. López Ortega. *Research & Politics*.
- 2024 “Addressing climate change with behavioral science: A global intervention tournament in 63 countries.” TISP team (including A. López Ortega). *Science Advances*.
- 2024 “Instrumentally inclusive: the political psychology of homonationalism.” S. Turnbull-Dugarte and A. López Ortega. *American Political Science Review*.
- 2023 “Do Political Duos Diminish Discriminatory Voter Preferences? Evidence from a Combined Conjoint.” A. López Ortega. *European Union Politics*.
- 2023 “Personality is political (especially for populists).” A. López Ortega. *Journal of Public Opinion and Parties*.
- 2023 “Insights into the accuracy of social scientists’ forecasts of societal change.” The Forecasting Collaborative (including A. López Ortega). *Nature Human Behaviour*.
- 2021 “Do all voters appreciate rebels? Ideology moderates valence benefits from factional dissent.” A. López Ortega and J. Besch. *The Journal of Legislative Studies*.
- 2021 “Are microtargeted campaign messages more negative and diverse? An analysis of Facebook Ads in European election campaigns.” A. López Ortega. *European Political Science*.
- 2019 “Public Attitudes on Energy (In) Security: Evidence from Spain.” L. Muradova and A. López Ortega.

REIS.

Working Papers and Under Review

- WP M. van der Velden, A. López Ortega, D.J. Roth, and P. Guldmond. “Do We All Long for the Past? Investigating Nostalgia as a Persuasive Political Rhetorical Strategy.” Under review.
- WP A. Canalejo, J. Padilla, and A. López Ortega. “When the Party is Over: Explaining the Rise of the Spanish Far-Right SALF.” Under review.
- WP L. Balcells, A. López Ortega, and E. vanderWilden. “Does historical knowledge shape modern attitudes? Evidence from queerphobic violence in Francoist Spain.”
- WP A. López Ortega and A. Krouwel. “A Ship of Fools: Reality Polarization and Democratic Backsliding.” Working paper.
- WP A. López Ortega and S. Turnbull-Dugarte. “Selective (il)liberalism: The Multidimensionality of Group Identity Movers.” Working paper.
- WP A. López Ortega. “Swiping right, leaning right? Unequal dating market dynamics and sexual conservative backlash.”
- WP A. López Ortega. “Citizen backlash to foreign LGBTQ+ advocacy? Evidence from Kuwait.”

GRANTS AND AWARDS

- 2025 Best Article Award from the European Politics and Society Section, American Political Science Association (APSA))
- 2025 VENI grant, NWO Talent Program, Dutch Ministry of Education, Culture and Science (\$320,000)
- 2025 Travel grant, CES, Harvard University (\$1,500)
For assistance to MPSA 2025
- 2024 Ramón Areces Fellowship, CES, Harvard University (\$65,000)
For development of project on how nativism affect LGBTQ+ attitudes in Europe
- 2023 University of Zurich Research Grant (9,270 CHF)
For development of AI-powered experiments
- 2023 British Academy Grant (£7,460)
To conduct experiments on homonationalism and instrumental liberalism
- 2023 Next Gen Ideas Grant (\$1,500)
To study consequences of identity-driven factual polarization
- 2020 Georgetown University Visiting Research Grant (3,400 CHF)
For research on strategic support for LGBTQ+ causes as identity differentiation
- 2019 Best Paper Award, Spanish Association of Political Science (AECPA)
For pioneering visual conjoint experiment on discriminatory preferences
- 2016 POLEXP Prize
For master’s thesis on voting preferences using conjoint experiments
- 2014 Erasmus Grant
For one-year exchange at University of Luxembourg

INTERNATIONAL SCIENTIFIC LEADERSHIP

- 2023– Queer Politics Webinar

- Co-Organizer of international webinar series on LGBTQ+ politics research
- 2022–24 COST Action LGBTQ+ Methods Summer Schools (London, Venice, Cluj-Napoca)
Scientific Committee Member and Instructor providing methodological training
- 2021– LGBTQ+ Mentorship Program, European Political Science Association
Founder and Coordinator, connecting 50+ early-career researchers with established scholars
- 2022 University of Southampton Workshop on Identity Politics
Co-organizer of international workshop on identity politics methodology
- 2022 ECPR General Conference
Panel Organizer on experimental methods in studying identity politics
- 2018– PREDI Political Prediction Market
Co-director of European-wide platform helping citizens forecast social events

INVITED TALKS AND RESEARCH VISITS

- 2025 Washington University in St. Louis, St. Louis (CPAC)
“Uncovering Hidden History: How Past Anti-LGBTQ+ Repression Shapes Modern Attitudes in Spain”
- 2024 University of Oxford, Oxford
“Unequal dating market dynamics and sexual conservative backlash.”
- 2024-2025 Harvard University, Cambridge
“How nativism & out-group rejection explains support for illiberal policy positions”
- 2024 Boston University, Boston
“Selective (il)liberalism”
- 2023 UNED, Madrid
“Experimental Methods in Studying Concealed Prejudice”
- 2023 Autonomous University of Barcelona
“Visual vs. Text Conjoint Experiments”
- 2023 GESIS, Mannheim
“Intra- and inter-LGBTQ+ subgroup prejudice”

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 2025 New England Area Political Psychology Conference, Cambridge, USA
- 2025 Midwestern Political Science Association Conference, Chicago, USA
- 2024 American Political Science Association Conference, Philadelphia, USA
- 2024 European Political Science Association Conference, Cologne, Germany
- 2024 ECPR Joint Sessions, University of Leuphana, Lüneburg, Germany
- 2024 American Political Science Association Conference, Los Angeles, USA
- 2023 European Conference on Political Research, University of Prague, Czechia
- 2023 European Political Science Association Conference, Glasgow, UK
- 2023 Identity Politics Seminar, University of Southampton, UK
- 2022 American Political Science Association Conference, Montreal, Canada

- 2022 ECPR Joint Sessions, University of Edinburgh, UK
- 2022 International Communication Association Conference, Paris, France
- 2021 American Political Science Association Conference, Seattle, USA (online)
- 2020 International Society of Political Psychology Conference, Berlin, Germany (online)
- 2019 Digital Democracy Lab Conference, University of Zurich/ETH, Switzerland
- 2019 European Conference on Political Research, University of Wroclaw, Poland
- 2019 International Society of Political Psychology Conference, University of Lisbon, Portugal
- 2019 European Political Science Association Conference, University of Belfast, UK
- 2018 Challenger Parties Workshop, University of Zurich, Switzerland
- 2018 ECPR Joint Sessions, University of Nicosia, Cyprus

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- 2022–23 Master Thesis Supervisor (9 students)
Free University of Amsterdam, Political Communication Program
- 2022 Quantitative Text Analysis
Undergraduate seminar, Free University of Amsterdam
- 2019 Political Campaigns in Times of Big Data
Undergraduate seminar, University of Zurich
- 2018 Personalization of Politics
Undergraduate seminar, University of Zurich

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

- 2020 Swiss University Teaching Qualification
Comprehensive training in higher education pedagogy
- 2018 ECPR Summer School in Methods and Techniques, Central European University
Automated Collection of Web and Social Data (15h)
Big Data Analysis in the Social Sciences (15h)
- 2017 CESS/Essex Summer School, University of Oxford
Causal Inference and Experimental Design
Experimental Approaches to Data Analysis

SOCIETAL IMPACT AND KNOWLEDGE DISSEMINATION

- 2023– Dutch Zorg Institute
Policy Advisor providing evidence-based recommendations
- 2022 Spanish Government
Co-authored white paper on addressing identity-based polarization
- 2021–22 Center for Cultural Studies and Social Change
Organized seminar series for activists, journalists, and consultants
- 2018– Media Engagement
Research featured in 30+ publications across national newspaper outlets, radio, TV, and podcasts

2018– PREDI Political Prediction Market
Co-director of platform helping citizens forecast social events, featured in El Periodico

OPEN SCIENCE PRACTICES

Pre-registration of all experimental studies with detailed hypotheses and analytical plans

Public archiving of research data, experimental materials, and analysis code through open-access repositories

Prioritization of open-access publication venues and preprint distribution

Active promotion of research transparency in collaborative projects and mentorship relationships

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Advanced: R, Stata, experimental design, conjoint analysis, text analysis

Intermediate: LaTeX, French, experimental programming

Basic: Python, HTML, JavaScript

LANGUAGES

Spanish: Native

English: Fluent

French: Intermediate

Portuguese: Basic

Updated August 2025